river, Lieutenant General Sagat Singh used helicopters to airlift troops and supplies to within 40–60 km of Dhaka. This opened the possibility of the fall of Dhaka and the complete surrender of Pakistani forces. [14]

Circumstances were already pushing for a decisive conclusion to the conflict. Indian intelligence learned that a US naval task force led by the aircraft carrier *U.S.S. Enterprise* was about to enter the Bay of Bengal, a development corroborated by a subsequent *New York Times* article. While the task force's objective was interpreted by India as either deterring an Indian attack on West Pakistan, evacuating Pakistani forces from the East, or bombing Indian communications, its arrival would clearly have impeded further Indian operations. [15] On 13 December, Moscow joined Washington in proposing a UN Security Council resolution that would call for a ceasefire between India and Pakistan. If agreed, it would have eliminated the possibility of a Pakistani surrender.

Instead, at that crucial moment, India stepped up the military pressure on Dhaka. On 15 December, Yahya told his commander in Dhaka Lieutenant General A.A.K. Niazi that 'resistance is no longer humanly possible' but also asked Zulfikar Ali Bhutto at the UN Security Council to accept a resolution. [16] Bhutto ignored these instructions, tore up the proposed resolution at the Security Council and walked out after a dramatic speech. By then, Niazi's proposal for a cessation of hostilities had reached New Delhi. India demanded unconditional surrender by the 93,000 Pakistani troops in the theatre and on 16 December, the head of the Indian Army's Eastern Command Lieutenant General Jagjit Singh Aurora and Niazi signed the Instrument of Surrender.

In June and July 1972, in the aftermath of India's victory in the Bangladesh War, Indian and Pakistani leaders met in the Indian hill station of Shimla. Pakistan sought and achieved the return of captured territory and of over 90,000 Pakistani prisoners of war. India got an agreement for a bilateral demarcation of a Line of Control (LoC), thus greatly reducing the possibility of third-party mediation on Jammu and Kashmir. The Shimla Agreement is widely seen in India as a missed opportunity. India had the upper hand but was unable to achieve a final settlement on Jammu and